

TRUTH HAS COME AND FALSEHOOD HAS VANISHED

MUHAMMAD RECEIVES THE
DIVINE REVELATION (c. 610)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

The rise of Islam

BEFORE

c. 550 CE Fall of the Himyarite Kingdom in southern Arabia.

570 Birth of Muhammad.

611 Persian Khusrau Shah conquers the Byzantines in Egypt, Palestine, and Syria.

AFTER

622 Muhammad and his followers flee Mecca and take up residence in Medina.

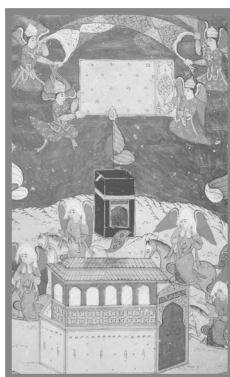
637 Muslim army captures Jerusalem after a siege.

640 Muslim general Amr ibn al-As conquers Egypt.

661 Umayyad caliphate established by Muawiya at Damascus, Syria.

711 Muslim armies cross into Spain and conquer the Christian Visigothic kingdom.

Around 610 CE, in a cave in the hills above the town of Mecca, central Arabia, Muhammad—a 40-year-old man from a merchant family—declared that he had received a divine message from the angel Gabriel. This was followed by similar revelations over the coming months and years and led to the founding of a new



In this

16th-century miniature The Kaaba, considered the house of God and the holiest shrine in Islam, is decorated by angels on the occasion of the Prophet Muhammad's birth.

monotheistic religion: Islam. Within 20 years, this creed had come to dominate the Arabian peninsula, and a century later its followers had shattered the ancient Byzantine and Persian Empires, creating a state that stretched from Spain in the far west to Central Asia in the east.

Arabia before Islam

From the first millennium BCE there were sophisticated kingdoms in southern Arabia, which derived their wealth from the spice trade. In the early days, the trade routes ran along the northwest coast, but by the 7th century these had diminished as merchants increasingly used a maritime route up the Red Sea, leaving many places that had been relatively prosperous in decline. There were a few scattered towns, such as Medina (then known as Yathrib) and Mecca, which were dependent on more local trade in wool and leather, along with a